

SOFIA VALDEZ

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SUMMARY

Product Manager with a technical background in AI and hardware, PhD-level research training, and entrepreneurial experience. Takes products from discovery to launch, with outcomes like a 2.5x conversion lift and \$4M+ in funding.

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Mechanical Engineering, Human-AI Interaction | *The University of Texas at Austin* **Aug 2020 – Aug 2025**
NSF Graduate Research Fellow

B.S., Mechanical Engineering, Product Development | *The University of Texas at Austin* **Aug 2016 – May 2020**
Minor: McCombs School of Business Foundations

EXPERIENCE

User Research Coordinator (Contract) | *Apple* **May 2026 – Jun 2026**

- Developed study protocols and conducted user studies as part of the Human Factors team.
- Automated data collection with AI, **cutting processing time by 97.5%**.

Associate Product Manager (Contract) | *Panda Mobile, T-Mobile Powered Carrier* **Sep 2024 – Mar 2025**

- Conducted usability interviews to diagnose onboarding drop-off** points and translated findings into product requirements and a benchmarked redesign that **drove 2.5x checkout conversion** within one month.
- Initiated market research on a new target segment** (25 in-depth interviews) and synthesized findings into a company-wide strategic presentation that **redirected multiple product and marketing investments**.

Doctoral Researcher, Human-AI Interaction | *The University of Texas at Austin* **Aug 2020 – Aug 2025**

- Built an AI-powered interactive design application in Python** from the ground up, including dataset generation, generative AI model training, and AI tool and interface development.
- Independently conducted mixed-methods user studies with 105 participants end-to-end**, from recruitment to data analysis, to measure how agency in AI-assisted design tasks shapes behavior and outcomes.
- Collaborated with industry partners to secure \$4M+ in funding to operationalize the AI-powered application** and conducted **50+ customer and stakeholder interviews** to drive iterative UX improvements.

Product Development Teaching Assistant | *The University of Texas at Austin* **Aug 2021 – May 2022**

- Guided student teams through the **full product design and development lifecycle of industry-sponsored projects (including NASA)**, from customer discovery and competitive analysis to PRDs and prototyping.

Founder of D2C Consumer Product Brand | *Independent* **Jan 2021 – Dec 2021**

- Developed and launched a consumer product to **#1 Best Seller status on Amazon and Etsy (~\$100K revenue)** owning brand and product strategy and e-commerce operations end-to-end.

Data Science (Intern) | *National Renewable Energy Laboratory* **Jun 2021 – Aug 2021**

- Resolved a SQL bottleneck in a data pipeline processing 1M+ readings per minute, cutting time by 98.6%.
- Built a machine learning model to predict energy efficiency months ahead for proactive resource planning.

Project Engineer (Intern) | *Halliburton* **Jun 2019 – Aug 2019**

- Conducted contextual inquiry and interviews** across two field sites with **50+ operators and engineers to diagnose a \$200K/year sand clogging issue; implemented solutions (including a custom filtration system)**.

SKILLS

Product & Strategy: market research, competitive analysis, UX research, PRDs, roadmap, GTM strategy, Agile, Scrum

Technical & Analytical: Python, R, SQL, Figma, machine learning, LLM prompt engineering, agentic AI